



Top of the world: Rudranksh Patil became the 10m air rifle world champion in 2022 and secured an Olympic Games Paris 2024 quota.

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competed in five Olympics, Abhinav has also been closely studying the sport and the methods used by leading countries over the years.

"The NRAI (National Rifle Association of India) has changed its approach. They are trying to do something different. It is all that they can do. Stick to a policy announced in advance. There is no clear pathway or strategy. Collectively, we must back it. Going forward, it is a journey. Hopefully, it will get the results," said Abhinav.

Yes, it is easy to find holes in the policy and criticise it. But as Abhinav pointed out, the dynamics of the shooting sport do not allow for a perfect plan and pathway.

"The USA has gone through many

formulae for Olympic selection. They had their own selection to choose the best. Then, they changed, giving one of the two quota winners the chance for automatic selection based on consistent performances. World Championship certain score, reach a certain level to gain automatic selection. The US has now changed. The situation is dynamic and pragmatic in the current environment. The current policy gives hope that the results will be positive. They are working on the dynamics," said Abhinav.

Looking closely at the selection policy, Olympian and coach of the cream of Indian rifle shooting, Deepali Deshpande, felt that "deemed quota winner" getting the same status as quota winners was weird.

To understand the deemed quota, it may be recalled that Tilottama Sen finished fourth in the World Championship but could not win the Olympic quota as Mehuli had won the quota with a silver. Luckily, Tilottama

went on to win the quota later and thus did not need the advantage of a "deemed quota".

"Winning quota is a different mindset. There is also a difference in winning the quota in the World Championship, Asian Championship, or much later in the qualifiers. It is not fair to treat all of them alike or give the same advantage to deemed quota winners as quota winners," observed Deepali, who trains Sift Kaur Samra, Shriyanka Sadangi, Swapnil Kusale, and Akhil Sheoran apart from Olympian Anjum Moudgil.

Deepali did agree that the World Champion, Rudranksh, deserved something special for the achievement.

"Rudranksh is perhaps a little chilled. I really hope that he peaks at the right time and gets back to his level. The advantage of winning the Olympic quota is only 0.33 points. You are not giving them the right advantage for winning the quota," said Deepali.

The advantage of winning the finals in trials is also negligible, and the bonus points for the first four places starting from 0.75 to 0.10 are kept separately to be considered only for breaking the tie after the tabulation of trial scores.

Now, compare that with the bonus points of 6, 4, 2, and 1 for the first four placed shooters in shotgun trials. Moreover, the shotgun shooters also get bonus points of 10, 8, 6, and 5 for the first four places in the World Championships. There are also high bonuses for similar spots in Asian championships, World Cups, and the final Olympic qualification event.

It is pertinent to note that the

« Abhinav Bindra won the 10m air rifle gold at the Olympic Games in Beijing in 2008. »

